DECODE UPSC with Mounika

November 2nd Week Current Affairs 2026

Reading script · voice only · English + తెలుగు · 13 topics + persons & places · Sunday 15 November, 6 PM

Script

Inflation has crossed the Reserve Bank’s red line, a fresh push for women’s reservation has reopened the north–south debate, Delhi breathed air about 17 times the safe limit on Deepavali, and India’s exports have hit an all-time high.

ఈ వారం చాలా important!

I am Mounika, and today we decode the 13 strongest stories of November’s second week, with real data, clear diagrams and one practice question after every topic, plus a quick round of persons and places in news.

మన ప్రయాణం start చేద్దాం.

Here is our map: five stories on the economy, four on polity and society, four on environment, health and the world, and then persons and places in news.

1 · Inflation crosses the red line

Story one: why has inflation crossed the Reserve Bank’s red line?

Retail inflation in October rose to 6.09%, up from 5.54 in September, according to the Ministry of Statistics. Food inflation jumped from 7.74 to 8.94%, and onion prices alone rose by about 116% in a year.

Now the framework. Since 2016, the Reserve Bank Act sets a target of 4% consumer inflation, with a band of 2% on either side, so 6% is the upper limit. The six-member Monetary Policy Committee sets the repo rate to keep inflation inside this band. And if average inflation stays outside the band for three quarters in a row, the Reserve Bank must report to the government, explaining why, and what it will do.

So what does this mean? When food prices drive inflation, a rate hike cannot grow more onions, so the quicker tools are on the supply side: buffer stocks, imports and better storage. But if high food prices spread into wages and other goods, the Committee may have to act. And notice: this October number comes from the new consumer price series, with base year 2024.

Prelims trap: consumer price data is released by the National Statistics Office in the Ministry of Statistics, not by the Reserve Bank; and the inflation target is set by the government in consultation with the Reserve Bank, not by the Monetary Policy Committee alone.

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MCQ (the question is on screen): Your first question of the day: how many of these three statements are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is B, only two. The Reserve Bank does not release consumer price data; the Statistics Ministry does.

2 · Women’s reservation and delimitation

Story two: women’s reservation was passed in 2023, so why is it still not in force?

The 106th Amendment of 2023 reserves one-third of seats in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies for women. But Article 334A says it will start only after a delimitation based on the first census taken after that law, and the reservation then lasts 15 years. So the chain is: census, then delimitation, then reservation.

In April this year, the government tried to speed this up with the Constitution 131st Amendment Bill, which would also expand the Lok Sabha from 543 seats to as many as 850. It failed in the Lok Sabha, 298 votes to 230, short of the two-thirds it needed. Now the government is reported to be planning a special session to try again.

Why the fight? Seats are shared by population. States that controlled their population, mostly in the south, fear losing their share of seats, while faster-growing states, mostly in the north, would gain. That is why the 84th Amendment of 2001 froze the seat shares until the first census after 2026.

అంటే, ఇది just women's reservation కాదు; it is about federal balance.

Prelims trap: a constitutional amendment needs a special majority: a majority of the total membership of the House, and two-thirds of those present and voting. That is why the April bill failed, even with more votes for it than against.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Now a Statement-one, Statement-two question. Decide whether the second explains the first.

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is A. Both are correct, and the special majority rule explains why more votes for the bill were still not enough.

3 · What did Delhi breathe on Deepavali?

Story three: what did Delhi really breathe on Deepavali night?

According to the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air, Delhi's average fine dust, PM 2.5, on Deepavali, November eighth, was 257 micrograms per cubic metre: more than four times India's own daily standard of 60, and about 17 times the World Health Organization's guideline of 15. That night, 20 of Delhi's 59 stations were in the severe category, and at the worst hour, 36 monitoring stations were not reporting data at all.

Delhi's emergency plan, the Graded Response Action Plan, works like a ladder: stage 1 when the Air Quality Index is poor, 201 to 300; stage 2 when it is very poor, 301 to 400; stage 3 when it is severe, 401 to 450; and stage 4, severe plus, above 450, which can stop construction and most trucks.

But crackers are only the spark. Winter brings calm winds and a temperature inversion, which works like a lid and traps smoke near the ground; stubble fires in Punjab and Haryana add to it; and vehicles and dust are always there. So even with green crackers, one night can push a city that is already choking into the severe zone.

Prelims trap: the Graded Response Action Plan is enforced by the Commission for Air Quality Management, a statutory body set up by a 2021 Act, not by the Central Pollution Control Board.

ఇది గుర్తుపెట్టుకోండి.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Pause and answer: how many of these three statements are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is C, all three. Severe is 401 to 450, India's daily standard is 60, and the Commission enforces the plan.

Bridge

Three big stories done, 10 to go.

మీరు ఇక్కడ వరకు ఉంటే, మీరు serious aspirant!

Now let us go from the air we breathe to the health of our people.

4 · WHO Global TB Report 2026

Story four: India has a quarter of the world's tuberculosis. Is that changing?

The World Health Organization’s Global Tuberculosis Report 2026 says India still accounts for about one in four TB cases in the world, and about 23% of TB deaths. But India’s TB death rate has fallen 38% since 2015, from about 280 to 180 deaths per million people, a little faster than the global fall of 35%.

Worldwide, about 10.6 million people fell ill with TB in 2025, and 1.13 million died. And notice this: the World Health Organization has not published India’s new incidence estimates this year, because they are being reviewed.

Why is TB so stubborn? It spreads through the air in crowded homes, it feeds on undernutrition, and drug-resistant TB needs long, costly treatment; India is among four countries with over half the world’s multidrug-resistant cases. That is why nutrition support under the Nikshay Poshan Yojana matters as much as medicines.

Prelims trap: the global goal to end TB is 2030, under the Sustainable Development Goals, but India had set itself an earlier target of 2025, which it has missed.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Which one of these statements about TB is correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is B: India accounts for about a quarter of the world’s TB cases. Remember, the 38% fall is in deaths, not in cases.

5 · Record exports in October

Story five: India just had its best month ever for exports. What does it really mean?

In October, merchandise exports touched a record 49.47 billion dollars, up about 45% from a year ago. Engineering goods rose 36%, electronics 63%, and petroleum products 140%.

But goods imports were 89.35 billion dollars, so the goods trade deficit was about 40 billion. Services saved the day: services exports of about 40.5 billion dollars, against imports of about 20.7, brought the overall deficit down to about 20 billion.

So India still buys more goods than it sells, mainly crude oil, electronics and gold, but earns a big surplus from services like software and business services. And watch petroleum: India imports crude, refines it and exports the products, so oil prices move both our imports and our exports.

Prelims trap: the trade balance covers only goods and services; the current account also adds remittances and income flows, and India is the world’s largest receiver of remittances.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Four statements on trade. How many of them are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is C, only three. India ran a goods trade deficit in October, not a surplus.

6 · World Bank: half a billion out of poverty?

Story six: half a billion Indians out of poverty, but measured by which line?

The World Bank’s October brief says extreme poverty in India, at 3 dollars a day, fell from 27.1% in 2011 to 2.6% in 2023; at the higher line of 4 dollars 20, it fell from 57.7 to 16.1%. Remember, the World Bank raised its international poverty line to 3 dollars a day in 2025, and critics say part of the fall reflects new data and methods.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Quick one: who publishes the global Multidimensional Poverty Index?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is B: the United Nations Development Programme with Oxford; in India, NITI Aayog publishes the national index, and the World Bank measures income and spending.

7 · Cabinet: credit for entrepreneurs, subsidy for farmers

Story seven: three Cabinet decisions for small entrepreneurs and farmers.

Stand-Up India, launched in 2016, gives loans of 10 lakh to 1 crore rupees to Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribe and women entrepreneurs for new enterprises, and now runs till March 2031. The Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Units, which backs small Mudra loans, also runs till 2031, with a corpus of 5,000 crore

rupees. For the rabi season, the Cabinet approved about 62,370 crore rupees of nutrient-based subsidy for phosphatic and potassic fertilisers, and it also cleared about 3,230 crore rupees for the Yuge Yugeen Bharat Museum in the old North and South Block.

Prelims trap: urea is not covered by the nutrient-based subsidy; it has its own controlled price. The nutrient-based system, in place since 2010, covers phosphatic and potassic fertilisers like D A P.

MCQ (the question is on screen): How many of these three statements are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is B, only two. Urea is outside the nutrient-based subsidy.

8 · Why ban the export of battery black mass?

Story eight: why did India ban the export of battery black mass?

When old lithium-ion batteries are shredded, they leave a dark powder called black mass, rich in lithium, nickel, cobalt, manganese and graphite. On November 11th, the Directorate General of Foreign Trade moved it from free to prohibited for export, under the Foreign Trade Development and Regulation Act of 1992.

Why? Remember last week's story: 2,814 crore rupees for processing lithium and nickel, and a 1,500 crore rupee recycling scheme. Keeping black mass at home feeds those plants, because recycling is a mine above the ground for a country with few lithium reserves.

MCQ (the question is on screen): The Directorate General of Foreign Trade works under which ministry?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is B, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

9 · UNEP Adaptation Gap: "Ready? Not."

Story nine: is the world ready for the warming that is already coming?

The United Nations Environment Programme's Adaptation Gap Report 2026, titled Ready? Not., says developing countries will need about 305 billion dollars a year for adaptation by 2035, but in 2024 they received only about 28 to 32 billion in public adaptation finance. Even tripling it would cover only 20 to 29% of the need.

Simple గా: mitigation అంటే తగ్గించడం, adaptation అంటే తట్టుకోవడం.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Match the report with its publisher. How many pairs are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is C, all three.

Bridge

Nine done!

ఇప్పుడు మన rivers, rights and the world వైపు చూద్దాం.

10 · The Siang dam and the Adi protests

Story 10: why are the Adi people of Arunachal Pradesh protesting a dam on the Siang?

One river, many names: it rises in Tibet as the Yarlung Tsangpo, enters Arunachal Pradesh as the Siang, becomes the Brahmaputra in Assam, and is called the Jamuna in Bangladesh.

The Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, planned at around 11,000 megawatts, is meant to store water and act as a buffer, especially because China has begun a giant hydropower project upstream on the Yarlung Tsangpo. But the Adi community fears that dozens of villages could be submerged, and the protests continue.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Match the river's name with the region. How many pairs are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is B, only two. The Jamuna is the name in Bangladesh, not in Assam.

11 · Karnataka’s quota and the Ninth Schedule

Story 11: can Karnataka save its higher quota through the Ninth Schedule?

In 2022 Karnataka raised Scheduled Caste reservation from 15 to 17% and Scheduled Tribe reservation from three to 7%, taking total reservation to 56%. In October, the High Court struck down the hike for breaching the 50% ceiling, and the state now wants the law placed in the Ninth Schedule.

The Ninth Schedule was added by the First Amendment in 1951, with Article 31B, to protect land reform laws from court challenges. The Indra Sawhney judgment of 1992 set the 50% ceiling, and Tamil Nadu’s 69% reservation went into the Ninth Schedule through the 76th Amendment of 1994. But in I R Coelho, in 2007, the Supreme Court held that laws added after April 24th, 1973, can still be tested against the basic structure.

Prelims trap: only Parliament, through a constitutional amendment, can add a law to the Ninth Schedule; a state legislature cannot.

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MCQ (the question is on screen): How many of these three statements are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is A, only one. The Ninth Schedule came with the First Amendment; but its laws are not fully immune, and a state cannot add them.

12 · IMNEX-26 and the exercise trap

Story 12, from the sea: IMNEX 26.

The eighth India–Myanmar Naval Exercise, IMNEX 26, was held at Visakhapatnam from November 10th to 14th, with the Indian Naval Ships Rana and Sumedha. Now the trap table: SLINEX is the navy exercise with Sri Lanka, Mitra Shakti is the army exercise with Sri Lanka, and Malabar brings together India, the United States, Japan and Australia.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Four exercise pairs. How many are correctly matched?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is D, all four.

13 · Children’s Day and the ‘which day’ trap

And story 13: today, November 14th, is Children’s Day.

India marks Children’s Day on November 14th, Jawaharlal Nehru’s birthday, while the United Nations’ Universal Children’s Day is November 20th. And on November 11th, we marked National Education Day for Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, our first Education Minister, while the United Nations’ International Day of Education is January 24th.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Last question of the day: how many of these three statements are correct?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is B, only two. National Education Day is for Maulana Azad, not Doctor Radhakrishnan.

14 · Persons, places and awards in news

Before we finish, a quick Prelims round: persons, places and awards in news.

First, persons. Anuj Shrivatri of Madhya Pradesh became India’s 100th chess Grandmaster on November eighth, the first from his state; remember, India’s first Grandmaster was Viswanathan Anand, in 1988. British writer M John Harrison won the Booker Prize 2026 for The End of Everything, and is reported to be its oldest winner. And at the National Sports Awards on November 13th, 17 athletes received the Arjuna Award, including Tejaswin Shankar, Divya Deshmukh and Vidit Gujrathi, but no one was selected for the Khel Ratna this year.

Now places. Antalya, on Türkiye’s Mediterranean coast, is hosting the climate summit COP 31, from November ninth to 20th, with Australia leading the negotiations. Manila in the Philippines hosts the ASEAN and East Asia Summits next week; India is a member of the East Asia Summit, but not of ASEAN.

Shenzhen in China hosts the APEC leaders, and remember, India is not an APEC member. And Mekedatu in Karnataka is back in the news: Karnataka wants clearance for a 16,745 crore rupee balancing reservoir on the Cauvery, inside the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary, while Tamil Nadu opposes it.

MCQ (the question is on screen): Four pairs from this round. How many are correctly matched?

(stay silent for 6 seconds)

The answer is C, only three. Mekedatu is on the Cauvery, not the Krishna.

Mains question

And for Mains, here is this week’s one writing question: should Lok Sabha seat shares stay frozen to protect states that controlled their population? Discuss it with reference to women’s reservation and delimitation. Write 250 words, and

మీ answer comments లో రాయండి.

All 14 practice questions, with answers, are in the practice sheet linked in the description.

Close

That was November’s second week: 13 stories, with the data and the diagrams behind each one. If this helped, share it with one friend who is preparing with you, and subscribe for every Sunday’s class. All the best, and see you next Sunday!